

Block

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ANALYTICAL WRITING

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BLOCK 2 ANALYTICAL WRITING

The profession of Journalism basically involves specialized writing and storytelling skills. And most of it is straight reporting of events as they unfold in a factual as well as interesting manner keeping the reader's interest and attention span in mind. But the newspapers and magazines offer much more to a reader in the form of features, opinion, editorial and so on. These are mostly written by the senior veterans in the profession who have both adequate knowledge and experience in the field. It is usually the expanded version written after detailed study of an issue and analysis. It is usually a well crafted piece of writing capable of attracting and holding the attention of a segment of dedicated readers.

This Block attempts to cover the various types of analytical writing in the following four Units.

Unit 5: Feature Writing : This Unit while listing the important ingredients of feature articles explains the difference between this form and news as well as other journalistic writings. The different categories of features such as news features, special events, personality interviews, how-to, background, investigative, colour, adventure, opinion, human interest, development features are explained briefly. Also how to write a feature article has been explained step-by-step. At the end, aspects pertaining to freelancing of features like studying the market for selling the features and tips for contacting the editors has been given.

Unit 6: Opinion Writing: This Unit begins with defining and listing the important components of an opinion writing piece. It then dwells on the difference between this form of writing and others such as editorial, feature, special write –ups and middles. The author then covers the universe of opinion writing ranging from issues of politics, ideology, social issues, public policy, culture and education. Characteristics of an opinion piece such as timeliness, subject knowledge, expertise, clarity of view point, unique/ uncommon opinion, and bearing the audience in mind are briefly touched upon in this Unit. Also how to plan and write an opinion piece has been explained. The Unit ends with a brief on the scope of opinion writing.

Unit 7: Editorial Writing: This Unit begins with a brief history of editorial writing and its evolution as an integral part of print media and its present connect with readers. The Unit deals with content and types of editorial. It gives elaborate step-by-step guidance for writing an editorial. It ends with a brief on the role of editorials in the changing media scenario.

Unit 8: Writing for Magazines : This Unit begins with tracing the historical background of the term 'magazine' and goes on to define it. It then spells out the constituents, characteristics and functions of a magazine. The Unit then describes different magazine writing styles and how to write for magazines by differentiating this from other journalistic writings. Also listed are various *genres* of magazine writing. At this juncture, the author also briefly touches upon the sharp decline in magazine journalism and setbacks to magazine writing as a result of it. The Unit ends with tips on how to choose topics, sources and do research for magazine writing. There is a section at the end on which magazine will publish the writings. This block will certainly be a handy ready reckoner for any aspiring journalist.

UNIT 5 FEATURE WRITING

Structure

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- 5.1 Learning Outcomes
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 - 5.2.2 Difference Between Feature Writing and News Writing
 - 5.2.3 Feature Writing and Other Journalistic Writings
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 - 5.5.2 Addressing/Contacting Editors
- 5.6 Let Us Sum Up
- 5.7 Further Reading
- 5.8 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

5.0 INTRODUCTION

As a student of journalism, you would have realized by now that these days no aspect of human life is untouched or unaffected by mass media's 24x7x365 hectic operations. Besides, as you know, the print and electronic media- newspapers, magazines and journals, television, radio and Internet churn out all kinds of news, views, and hugely multifarious variety of other printed stuff from every nook and corner of the globe. Daily newspaper only adds to normally what we already know by the time it is delivered at our doorstep in the morning.

However, there is one specific area of print journalism relating to various aspects of human endeavor, which though covered very well by print media, but which is not adequately attended to by the electronic media. Yet, the readers avidly look forward to it day- in and day-out. This crucial area of print journalism is called 'feature article'.

And why is this so? Because what the newspapers accomplish with features, it is believed, is difficult for other media to achieve. A short perusal of any daily newspaper will prove this point. The feature article has in recent times, therefore, come to acquire a prominent place in our daily dose of reading- be it the daily newspaper, magazines, newsletters-weekly, fortnightly, monthly, or of any other periodicity.

Thus, with a view to telling you as to how this can be done, in this Unit, we will discuss at length: what is a feature article, what are the various kinds of

features, how are features written, and how you can sell your feature article and make money from this genre of popular journalistic writing.

5.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After you have gone through this Unit, it is hoped that you will be able to:

- comprehend as to what a feature article is;
- understand the difference between a ‘news story’ and a ‘feature’, an ‘editorial’ and a ‘feature’, a ‘backgrounder’ and a ‘feature’;
- recognize the difference between a feature article and various other journalistic writings;
- learn about the various kinds / types / categories of features;
- actually write a feature article;
- and, finally, understand how to make money by writing features.

5.2 DEFINITION

What is a feature? The briefest answer is: ‘anything that is not news’. However, simply and crisply stated, a feature article is also a type of journalistic writing that ‘entertains and informs.’

Described precisely and in other words, a feature article is a piece written with a view to elaborate about an exclusive or a particular characteristic—distinct, special, marked, specific designated information or details of an issue, knowledge or guidance on a given event or an happening, subject or a place. It is not a news story.

Currently, since the print media, particularly the daily newspapers, news magazines, and newsletters carrying news reports are experiencing tough times due to declining circulation, and huge financial downturn, feature articles and feature stories are getting increased attention for attracting higher readerships and beefing up their presence in the marketplace. This is particularly so because features are written in simple, casual, and popular language, and are easily digested by the reader. These writings are of lasting value with a longer shelf life and are not perishable like a news item.

Also, more readers want to read features because these are hugely instrumental in informing them on issues they are ignorant about and places they will never visit. As stated by Sharon Wheeler, a noted British journalism teacher, who adds further that ‘they (readers) want to be given an insight into a famous person’s life and what makes them tick...want to be outraged when a miscarriage of justice is revealed...a complicated issue to be broken down into layperson’s terms...want an armchair view of the gig we couldn’t attend.’

This is exactly what today’s features in newspapers is and news magazines are expected to achieve. But the news stories can’t.

5.2.1 Important Ingredients of Feature Articles

To be able to write a good feature article, one needs to possess ‘gift of the gab’ and a superb command on the language. In addition, the writer needs to be

talented enough and equipped with thinking skills to approach the subject from multiple ways. Here are some important and crucial elements and ingredients that can make your feature an attractive read and for you to be hailed as a good feature writer:

- *Immaculate Language*: Flawless, racy, grammatically infallible, and simple language will quickly win and retain the reader for all times to come. Use difficult words rarely; avoid unfamiliar jargons; abhor intricate ideas; resist verbose phrases and heavily loaded sentences.
- *Express your own views on the topic frankly, unreservedly*: Readers are interested in knowing what you as a writer think about the issue you are dwelling on. Develop your own thoughts in a logical, cogent, chronological and engaging style. Let the readers have dig into your mind. It will make the reader support you and be your fan, if you are successful in earning his loyalty by offering what ordinarily most readers are looking for.
- *Be Personal*: The trick is to instantly involve the reader on what you are drumming about. Give your own colour, innate description, try and gauge, solicit the spectator's mood, facial expressions, his personal views, quote his /her words verbatim, colour of his shirt / saree / jean / hairstyle / age / looks-whatever, howsoever you can do it. Don't hesitate; the readers love it. They will always follow your writings.
- *Interview/Converse/Dialogue*: As stated earlier, quoting the people on-the-spot adds profuse authenticity and value to your writings / views. Always be on the look out for an opportunity to pick up and quote key, punchy words from the conversation, or dialogue you are having with any interviewee.
- *Features are Longer Than News Stories*: In order to provide abundant and self-contained information, by a feature, it has often to be longer than a news item. The news story merely offers snippets, but a feature is more than that. Generally acceptable length of a feature is between 1,000 and 1,200 words for a daily newspaper, and between 1,500 and 2,000 words for a magazine. Magazines usually have longer shelf life and retentional value than a daily newspaper.
- *Pictures, Pictures, and more Pictures*: Remember, no good feature will look attractive enough or be acceptable for publication without at least a couple of good pictures on the most discussed aspect of the feature article. A pretty face, latest saree design, a beautiful figure always attract a discriminating, discerning, intelligent reader. Don't forget that a crisply done feature on an up-to-date, hot, burning, highly debated issue or topic is perhaps the best marketing prank to allure the clientele to your publication, and make it sell.
- Finally, *Look Ahead*: Plan a feature for the forthcoming occasions. Be imaginative, think ahead of others. Many new things are going to happen in the not too distant future. Local, regional, national events are planned much ahead. Be knowledgeable about such events; collect materials and relevant information about such forthcoming events much in advance and be ready with your piece at least three-four weeks in advance. Festivals, for example—Diwali, Eid, Republic Day, Christmas, New Year ... the list is endless. Just think! This will enable publications in accepting and scheduling the publication of your feature on the dot—on the very day the event is due.

You will win accolades from the readers, appreciation from your fans. And, some good money for yourself too!

Here's the list of language do's and don'ts: Choose the precise word; be simple and concise; prefer a familiar word to the unfamiliar; use the concrete rather than the abstract; avoid clichés; be positive and honest; try to write as you speak; and, vary your pace and rhythm. (Brendan Hennessy: Writing Feature Articles, 2006.)

5.2.2 Difference Between News Writing and Feature Writing

By now you may surely know what is 'news', and how it is written: A news story has to be objective, topical, fresh, bare facts, generally fitted in a strait-jacket frame to meet the text-book discipline, i.e., 5 Ws and 1 H. But a feature article is not necessarily written in that formulaic manner.

As you know well, writing a news story has to be done within a tight deadline after which the story loses its worth. A feature article can, however, be written in a comparatively somewhat relaxed, easy timeline. There is plenty of scope for packing multiple viewpoints in a feature, yet that may not be feasible or necessary in all features.

However, a news story is usually done in the pyramid style i.e., facts are presented from the top to bottom in a structured manner. News items are written in an impersonalised manner; often the reporter's view has no place in the body of the news story. Quotes have to be ascribed to the sources, crucial people on the spot, whose views are vital and added to the facts pertaining to the story and written within inverted commas (" "), also called Quotes.

In order to be effective, news stories have to be short, sharp, to the point, crisp, packing maximum information in fewest words to save valuable newspaper space, and also the harassed reader's time. But in order to be read and to retain the reader's attention for longer period, a feature has to offer much more details, be presented in a refined prose, and the language bedecked with lots of 'blossoms and flowers', to be an attractive experience, and to leave a lasting impression on the reader.

A news story, on the other hand, need not or may not be required to be accompanied by a picture at all. All news stories don't need to be illustrated with photographs. Besides, there is no space in the body of a newspaper for that.

Finally, since newspapers and magazines meet varied needs, and cater to diversified interests, the topics that suit newspaper features and magazine features will also thus essentially have to be varied. For example, while, magazines can, and actually many do, specialise in subjects such as the human interest issues, controversial national and international matters, social, cultural, religious, political problems, and so on, newspapers rarely follow that line.

5.2.3 Feature Writing and Other Journalistic Writings

As we have stated earlier, there is a vast difference between writing features for newspapers and magazines. Similarly, features also differ from other journalistic genres of writings.

While, there are really no hard and fast rules and regulations for defining or dividing these journalistic writings, these genres vary from newspaper to newspaper. In any case, a feature article is not hard news; it is not review; it is not a column; it is not an essay; it is not an editorial; it is not a filler; and it is not an advertorial.

But despite all that, there is a lot of commonalities amongst newspaper editorial contents all over the world. For example, most newspapers regularly carry editorial and op-ed pages; these news pages are designated as district/local; regional / state; national/news from capital; international/ foreign / world.

Sports/specific sports- IPL, ICL, hockey, football, cricket, kabaddi, kho-kho, wrestling, athletics, tennis, badminton, table tennis, shooting, swimming championships, etc. competitive sports, such as World/Asian/African/Twenty-Twenty/Commonwealth Cups and so on.

Other editorial content pages include: commerce/business/economy- stock exchanges-local, national, international; commodities, bullion rates; property, real estate etc. Entertainment forms an important aspect of any newspaper's content these days: review pages on cinema, films, CDs, television, music, theatre, radio, arts, books, etc. are usually found.

Then there are columns on motoring, gardening, public grievances, comic strips, cartoons, restaurants and hotels, food/recipes, wines/drinks/ladies wear/ men's clothes, footwear -for men, women and children.

The editorial and op-ed pages generally comprise: opinion, commentary, views, interviews, news analysis, backgrounders, rejoinders, obituaries and so on. Some newspapers also carry specially commissioned columns, extended write-ups on individual religions e.g. commentary from the Bhagwad Gita, Mahabharata, Quran, Bible, and other religious scriptures.

It may, however, be pointed out that though all these genres of writings are not journalistic, strictly speaking, but since these are published day- in and day- out, these have become part of the regular editorial content in most newspapers.

Check Your Progress 1

- Note:** 1) Use the space given below for your Answer.
2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What do you understand by a feature article?

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2. Differentiate between an article and a feature article

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5.3 KINDS/TYPES/FORMS/CATEGORIES OF FEATURES

Actually, there are no rigidly set up kinds or categories of features. However, eight categories of features have been recognized by many western- particularly British and American- professional journalists and noted journalism academicians.

These include:

News Features : Such features originate from and are based on important news happenings, involving VIPs or notorious criminals or influential personalities. The Indian Express, Delhi, specializes in such features - its recent news features on noted criminal, Yasin Bhatkhal and his associates, who are now in prison; Uttarakhand floods that caused huge damage to lives and property; jailing of Bihar's former chief minister, other state politicians and former IAS officers in the aftermath of the recent Supreme Court judgment on convicted politicians are some examples.

Special Event Features: India holding Commonwealth Games, Delhi University organizing Annual Session of the 90th Indian Science Congress, India hosting the UNESCO Annual Meet or Delhi being the venue of Commonwealth Heads of Government Conference (CHOGM) etc. would all be deemed as special events. Everything connected with these events would form excellent theme for a feature.

Personality Feature : Doing a personal profile of the United Nations General Secretary, Ban ki-Moon, visiting India for the first time after his appointment; or writing about the former US President's wife, Michelle Obama's, journey to the American White House could be good subjects under this head.

Interview Feature: Talking to maestro singer Lata Mangeshkar, after she was awarded the Bharat Ratna about her life story, and her life-long achievements as a musician: tracing her early career years can be an ideal topic for an interview feature. Also stories like speaking to the 70-year-old Japanese who scaled the Mount Everest without oxygen would also be an excellent idea for such a story.

How-to Features: Such features are written for guiding users on how to operate or handle sensitive, costly equipment, doing hazardous experiments or executing dangerous jobs. The purpose is to instruct the user step-by-step, operation by operation, for performing the activity, or accomplishing a tedious job expected from the gadget or equipment. This helps the user to avoid accidents.

Background Features : Doing a report on an incident that may be connected with an old, historical or ancient event. When the Clock Tower in Delhi's Chandani Chowk fell down several years ago, many newspapers wrote detailed pieces on its background. Similarly, when the Indian Science Congress holds its Annual session readers would like to learn about its history, functions, achievements, etc. These tit-bits can form highly readable background features.

Investigative Features : Investigating the criminal career of the Bhatkhal brothers and their associates can be an investigative feature. Probing the causes of communal flare-ups in different part of the country would be good subjects for investigative features.

Colour Features : These features are generally written on the subjects of which the authors have deep knowledge and thorough understanding, besides adequate

command of the language. Often, these topics tend to be light, more descriptive, with frequent creative play on the words, capturing the moods of a special occasion such as a fair, holiday season with happiness and mirth flirting all around.

Adventure Features: Remember the young Kolkata girl, Bachandri Pal, the first Indian woman to have climbed the Mount Everest. Hers was a unique feat, and that formed a subject for an adventure feature. In this category also included are first time travels to tough, highly hazardous, frightening regions of Asia, Africa, Antarctica, etc.

Opinion Features : Such pieces are usually based on expertise or research and with the single aim of expressing personal views on a crucial subject. That person's findings should, however, weigh heavily in the concerned circles. Historian Irfan Habib on Nehru-Jinnah connections, India's former foreign Secretary's view on Sino-Indian border dispute, or US role in the Middle East, or Chinese activities in the South-East Asia, US's former Secretary of State advocating a permanent membership for India in the UN Security Council come under this category.

Human Interest Features : A young boy who lost both his hands in a rail accident, and paints beautiful sceneries with a paint brush tucked under his teeth, or the brush held in his feet or a high school passout government clerk winning Rs. 5-crore in the television shows "Kaun Banega Crorepati" show would be most readable feature stories.

Development Features: As you would have understood, development communication is an integral part of modern day media research and education. Development stories from remote, far flung areas could present fascinating account and be interesting feature reflecting the progress ordinary people there have made.

5.4 HOW TO WRITE A FEATURE ARTICLE?

As we have seen, there are subjects galore for writing feature articles. All one needs to be able to write good features are skill and perception to recognize the subjects that one wishes to write on. However, before undertaking to do so, it would be prudent to learn more about the art and craft of writing a feature article.

The first and the foremost consideration should be to make sure that one has adequate ability and competence to accomplish the task to the satisfaction of the Editor. And it would be appropriate to consider adopting the following steps for writing the piece.

As you know, every good piece of writing has to have a beginning, a middle, and an end. While one may have some hazy idea of how the piece will look like, but it is always prudent to draw a plan.

Therefore, a feature should have the LEAD, or the opening paragraph. But, this first para will have to be structured differently than the one in case of a new story. The first para of a feature article should attract, arrest, and hold the attention of the reader and make him read it. If that happens instantly, the writer should be deemed to have well succeeded in his /her object. However, this lead para could be an abrupt, curt statement, an anecdote, or a description of a set scene. A dialogue could also be used as a lead.

After the lead, the second stage is TRANSITION, addressed to the reader explaining in a capsule form your reason in attempting to write this piece. This part should further sharpen the inquisitiveness of the reader and propel him/her to continue reading till the end.

The third stage of the feature is termed DEVELOPMENT. In this section, the theme / issue / subject of the feature should be developed further. This portion of the feature is the heart and soul of the feature. It should be elaborated logically, chronologically, systematically, and carefully keeping in mind that the reader has been fully engaged, and that his/her interest in the piece is not wearing thin. The paras should be interconnected, moving step-by-step, point-by-point, doling out information one after the other; making sure that each point supplements the other.

Finally, the feature should end in a manner that the reader is amply satisfied. And, he / she should be made to realize that he/she has had an interesting, amusing, exciting, enjoyable and pleasing experience reading your piece. The conclusion could be in the form of another short anecdote (based on theme of the feature only), another terse, quip, gibe or a joke; leaving the reader smiling and with remarks like an ah, ooh, well done!

While these points are no rigid formula, but if the writer pursues these suggestions, the feature should be able to leave an impressionable dent on the reader's mind. And if the writer has collected sufficient material, organized it well and presented it cogently, the piece will shape effectively. And it should be an enjoyable treat.

5.4.1 Choosing a Topic

If you have been reading your newspaper / magazine with all your senses wide open and alert, you would have found that all kinds of themes make excellent topics or subjects for features. Perhaps the best suggestion in this regard would be that whenever and wherever you are roaming about, just look around with keen eyes, sharp attentive inquisitive mind and there will be a feature right in front of you. If you are young, sports, pop stars, music, films, fashion, adventure, travel, motoring, food, science & technology, computers and cybernetics, meeting foreigners visiting your town should interest you as also the readers. And if you are middle aged, politics and politicians, finance, health, and health system such as gyms and spa, spiritual leaders/ godmen, career men and women, gardening, environment, food, law and order, legal system, defence and security paraphernalia would make some good topics for writing features. The list is endless; subjects umpteen; topics galore.

5.4.2 Preparations Needed

Once you have identified a topic to write a feature on, it is important that you are also fully equipped to write it well, and complete it on time. Meanwhile, as you sit at your computer, all your materials should be readily available to you so that your thought stream is uninterrupted.

The following professional writing tools are helpful and necessary and will assist you to do your job well: a rough draft, a tentative structure of the feature article; your notes; research and reference material you have gathered on the topic; list of printed sources, and newspaper/magazine clippings; promotional literature-posters, pamphlets, brochures, leaflets; good dictionary; Roget's Thesaurus; telephone directory; book of quotations; emails received; web sites; blogs; suitable pictures to go with the feature to highlight the main thrust of the article, etc.

This is only a suggestive list; of course, you will have your own material to consult and use for the article.

While you are preparing to write a feature for a particular newspaper, magazine or publication, it would be advisable for you to be aware of their editorial policy, main economic and political programmes and general and social reputation. Your piece has necessarily to be in total consonance and in complete agreement with the views of the management and the editor. In the absence of these requirements, your piece has lesser chances of being accepted for use in that newspaper or magazine.

5.4.3 Tapping Sources for Material

To do full justice to the theme of a feature article, the writer has to go about collecting material from several sources. While there are numerous sources to be tapped from, the writer has to know which source to tap, and what information to seek. For example, if the feature article is to be on delinquent children, or children addicted to certain drugs, the best sources will be the local government's department of welfare office for children, office of the drugs controller, local police department in charge of apprehending addicted children and reforming them. There will also be many non-governmental bodies involved in such tasks that can be contacted.

Similarly, there are many local, state, regional, national, and international organizations; voluntary associations; civic bodies; state and central government offices that provide key information and useful details on many subjects on which feature articles are written. These sources need to be tapped for the latest and accurate information. Materials procured from these organizations constitute integral part of features on the relevant topics, and can lend authenticity to features.

5.4.4 Researching the Topic

Most often, features have to be packed with facts, figures, statistics and happenings from the past - generally history. The feature writer's most important responsibility is to make sure that whatever details are provided in the features are accurate to the extent possible. In order to assure this, the writer has to do adequate research on the topic that is under treatment.

Thus, researching for the feature is an essential part of good writing. Moreover, a good feature has to reflect on all possible aspects of the topic. Therefore, consulting authoritative sources is imperative. Even editors using your feature will like this done as fully as possible. For, it will be the Editor who will have to bear the brunt in the event of inaccurate information found in the feature.

So, what is research? How is research done? Which and where are the sources for research? Consult your Editor. The Editor is the best person to tell you what exactly is required and what aspects of the feature are necessary and critical, and require latest thinking.

In any case, some of the following research sources are quite reliable: your office morgue -the clippings library that is maintained in every office. Newspaper cuttings, old magazine articles, notes and archives, reference materials -yearbooks, annuals, subject special handbooks- PR literature and publicity brochures, handouts, etc., also contain a variety of allied and useful information on your feature topic. Your colleagues in the publication across all its sections / divisions too can pitch in many useful suggestions, ideas. web sites, portals, blogs, news groups, facebook and several other social media discussions, university/public libraries too help a lot.

In addition, there are NGOs, voluntary, autonomous and government bodies, consumer and special groups, independent experts, academic researchers, social workers, private and commercial organizations, reports from government departments. And, finally, seek out the RTI for more.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your Answer.

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. If you are required to do a feature article on incidence of AIDS in your town, what sources would you tap?

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2. What criteria would adopt in choosing a subject for daily newspaper which is meant for young adults and another one for adults?

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3. What are the reference sources a feature writer should use?

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5.5 FREELANCING FEATURES

If you are a prolific writer, there is a plenty of scope for freelancing your features, and making some money too. While many newspapers and magazines do maintain their own regular Features Department, often replete with competent and experienced feature writers, but novel ideas for features are always acceptable and welcome. Even reputed and established publications are open to fresh, timeless, and off beat features. However, it is also important to know which newspaper or magazine wants what type of features, and when.

Usually, there are two ways of marketing features: features can be sold to 'Feature Syndicates' also. You can do it on your own: offer the same feature to local newspapers, regional papers and even foreign publications by personally contacting the editors. Some overseas publications will entertain features of interest only to sophisticated, knowledgeable sections of their society.

5.5.1 Studying Market for Selling Features

As stated above, the feature market is vast and operates at various levels: local, regional, national and worldwide. But, the moot question is: how to know who wants what, when, how much and how often?

There are two ways of knowing all these points: by personal contacts; and/or by being intimately familiar with the contents of publications, their policies, their political affiliations and financial standing, besides their general outlook such as circulations, interests of their readers whether they accept contributions from freelancers.

In addition, as freelance contributor, it would be profitable for you to know the nature of the contents of the publication you are aiming to send your feature to. As you know, almost every publication has its areas of interests laid down. One needs to know this. This can be gauged from the contents of a few of their issues. Besides the newspapers, specialized magazines' needs are obvious from their titles: Femina, Sports Star, Businessworld, Screen, Outlook, Filmfare, etc. There is no point in contacting them for contributing features if it is not in their forte.

5.5.2 Addressing/Contacting Editors

Perhaps you would know, it is the Editor of a publication who lays down rules and regulations on all crucial editorial matters. But, after once laying down general guidelines of the magazine/newspaper, he can not be expected to attend to every matter. Commissioning or accepting features articles are generally the responsibility of the News Editor/Features Editor or an Assistant Editor.

So, in such a situation, a feature journalist will do well to get in touch with the relevant person nominated for the job. While, it is convenient and possible to contact on telephone, but it is advisable to use email or personal written correspondence for eliciting information regarding. The nature of features acceptable, word limit, pictures deadlines, monthly, fortnightly, weekly of such requirement. An informal / personal response confirming the arrangement will seal the matter.

5.6 LET US SUM UP

In this Unit, our endeavour has been to familiarize you with almost all aspect of feature writing. With this end in view, this unit provided you the definition of a feature; listed the essential ingredients of a feature article; differentiated between a feature and other journalistic and media writings. We also detailed the various kinds/categories and types of features, and enlightened you about what goes in each type; then, we told you how to write a feature; how to choose topic for writing a feature; the kind of preparation you need to do to write the feature; how and what sources to tap and research to do for procuring adequate material to do the feature article. And, finally, we told you in detail how to freelance your features and contact editors for using your articles so that you can earn some money from your features.

5.7 FURTHER READING

1. Features for Flair, Press Institute of India, Chennai, India
2. Writing Feature Articles by Brendan Hennessy, Focal Press, Boston, USA
3. Feature Writing for Journalists by Sharon Wheeler, Routledge, New York, USA
4. The Essential Feature Writing for Magazines and Newspapers by Vicky Hay, Columbia University Press, New York, USA

5. Feature Writing for Newspapers and Magazines by Edward Jay Friedlander and John Lee, Pearson Press, Boston, USA

The Indian Express, New Delhi, carries at least two – three feature articles everyday. This paper publishes extended features almost daily. This paper's Sunday magazine, The Eye, also publishes two-three features every Sunday. A regular perusal of this magazine can help feature writers and would be feature journalists in brushing their skills further. You can also pursue other regional and national newspapers such as the the Telegraph, Kolkata; The Hindu, Chennai; The Tribune, Chandigarh; The Times of India, Mumbai. Notable magazines: India Today, Tehelka, Savvy, Celebrity, Open.

5.8 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. A feature article is a piece written with a view to elaborate about an exclusive or a particular characteristic distinct, special, marked, specific designated information or details of an issue, knowledge or guidance on a given event or an happening, subject or a place. It is not a news story.
2. A news story has to be objective, topical, fresh, bare facts, generally fitted in a strait-jacket frame to meet the text-book discipline, i.e., 5 Ws and 1 H. But a feature article is not necessarily written in that formulaic manner.

Check Your Progress 2

1. There are innumerable local, state, regional, national, and international organizations; voluntary associations; civic bodies; state and central government offices that provide key information and useful details on many subjects on which feature articles are written.
2. For young adults - sports, pop stars, music, films, fashion, adventure, travel, motoring, food, science & technology, computers and cybernetics. And for middle aged reader, politics and politicians, finance, health, and health system such as gyms and spa, spiritual leaders/ godmen, career men and women, gardening, environment, food, law and order, legal system, defence and security paraphernalia.
3. Newspaper office morgue - the news slip library with PR literature and publicity brochures, handouts, Web sites, portals, blogs, news groups, Facebook and several other social media discussions, and university/public libraries.

UNIT 6 OPINION WRITING

Structure

- 6.0 Introduction
- 6.1 Learning Outcomes
- 6.2 Definition
 - 6.2.1 Important Components of an Opinion Writing Piece
- 6.3 Difference between Opinion Writing and Other Forms of Journalistic Expression
 - 6.3.1 Editorial Writing and Opinion Writing
 - 6.3.2 Features and Opinion Writing
 - 6.3.3 Special Write-ups and Opinion Writing
 - 6.3.4 Middles and Opinion Writing
- 6.4 Universe of Opinion Writing
 - 6.4.1 Issues of Politics and Ideology
 - 6.4.2 Social Issues
 - 6.4.3 Issues of Public Policy
 - 6.4.4 Issues of Culture and Education
- 6.5 Characteristics of an Opinion Piece
 - 6.5.1 Timeliness
 - 6.5.2 Subject Knowledge, Expertise
 - 6.5.3 Clarity of Viewpoint
 - 6.5.4 Unique/ Uncommon Opinion
 - 6.5.5 Keep Audience in Mind
 - 6.5.6 Avoid Conflicts
- 6.6 How to Plan an Opinion Piece
 - 6.6.1 Think of a Topic
 - 6.6.2 Assess the Eco-system
 - 6.6.3 Collect Material
 - 6.6.4 Draw an Outline/Define Parameters
 - 6.6.5 Think of the Market
- 6.7 How to Write an Opinion Piece
 - 6.7.1 Importance of Intro
 - 6.7.2 Catchy Headlines
 - 6.7.3 The Structure of Opinion Piece
 - 6.7.4 Language and Style
 - 6.7.5 Choice of Words
 - 6.7.6 Editing
 - 6.7.7 Conclusion
- 6.8 Scope of Opinion Writing
- 6.9 Let Us Sum Up
- 6.10 Further Readings
- 6.11 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

6.0 INTRODUCTION

Opinion writing is fast gaining currency and acceptance as a form of media writing. By its very name the term opinion writing suggests that the expression of such views by the writers are personal and subjective on a topic that is of considerable interest to media audiences. Contrary to other heads under which media writing is done like – news stories, news features, interviews, editorials and even interpretative or investigative reporting, opinion writing makes no claims to objectivity. Readers look forward to the know the opinion or views of certain person(s), whether it may be a journalist or non-journalist, on a particular subject of interest to them and not necessarily to know the truth or facts.

Opinion writing is a unique form of mass media because even before the communication starts, the recipients have an idea of the message they will get. This cannot be said of any other form of message in media communication.

6.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After going through this Unit, the students will come to know about

- opinion writing and its importance;
- how opinion writing is different from other form of media writing such as news stories, features, editorials, interviews and research based write-ups;
- all those who can do opinion writing;
- the special features of opinion writing;
- what the readers expect in an opinion piece;
- how to market your opinion pieces.

6.2 DEFINITION

In opinion writing, the writer expresses his/ her opinion on a particular current issue or topic. Though there is no claim of it being objective or balanced, good opinion writers choose appropriate evidence to support and substantiate the opinion expressed. This may be in the form of research based data, opinion expressed by other experts on the subject or through citations and references for further reading.

An opinion writing piece basically contains viewpoint of a person, journalist or non-journalist subject expert on a topic of considerable readership interest. The topic has to be related to some current development that is the theme of public discourse. The subject should be of wide interest to arouse curiosity among people who want to know more about it.

6.2.1 Important Components of an Opinion Writing Piece

A good opinion piece should have the following attributes:

- a good catchy headline to attract the audiences of print, broadcast or social media alike;

- a topic of current interest to the audience or we may say a topic, that is of general discussion among people;
- thematic unity which can cater to the satisfaction of the audience; and
- a rational and well-arranged case presented in an analytical form of writing.

6.3 DIFFERENCE BETWEEN OPINION WRITING AND OTHER FORMS OF JOURNALISTIC EXPRESSION

The traditional way of categorization of contents of newspaper is to segregate all non-advertising matter into two heads news and views. It has been said with great conviction that while news is sacred views can be personal. This was the dictum of British press of the Victorian era on which newspapers in India tailored their contents for more than a century from the mid 19th century to the second half of the 20th century.

However, as the U.S. influence on Indian intelligentsia grew, especially after the information and communications technology (ICT) revolution and globalization, lobby journalism and advocacy journalism started gaining respectability in India. This was the origin and source of opinion writing in Indian media. It is, however, now fast emerging as a distinct format of media expression termed as opinion journalism.

Opinion writing is different from other forms of media writing in several ways and this is what you need to understand. Now let us see how it differs from the other forms of journalistic expression.

6.3.1 Editorial Writing and Opinion Writing

Editorials, as leaders are generally called, denote broader philosophy of a newspaper or journal and its outlook on various socio-political and economic issues. Leaders, therefore, express the consensus of the entire editorial team as well as management of a media organization. Compared with this, an opinion piece is expression of an individual writer and his/her viewpoint. You must have many times come across journals and websites put out a disclaimer at the end of a piece that the views contained therein are the personal views of a writer and these may or may not be the views of the journal or website or news portal as the case may be.

Moreover, leaders are generally balanced and sober, which may not be the case with opinion writing. In a leader the editorial writer tries to take into consideration all sides of an issue and then argue in favor of their editorial line. An opinion writer has no such compulsions.

6.3.2 Features and Opinion Writing

Features can broadly be divided into two categories – news features and non-news features. Features can broadly be divided into two categories – news features and non-news features. Opinion writing can also be on something which is currently in news or something which is not making news. Like opinion writing, features also convey the views of a writer on a subject. Yet, features are different from opinion writing. The essential difference is in language, style and presentation. While good features have flowery, twisted and even idiomatic language, opinion

pieces are straight and bold. While features are meant for leisure reading in a relaxed mood, opinion pieces force you to commit yourself to a certain viewpoint. Features do not put any demand on you to change your media behavior, thinking, attitude and psyche by persuading and convincing you but opinion pieces try to convert you to the writer's viewpoint.

6.3.3 Special Write-ups and Opinion Writing

Every good news media outlet invites subject specialists to write on complex and complicated issues which crop up in the public domain. These issues mostly pertain to defence, scientific research, health, environment, economic and fiscal policies which impact our lives.

However, most of us lack expertise to understand and analyse the implications of such issues. Special articles help us in developing our comprehension and to understand such complicated issues.

Special write-ups of course need handling of a topic or subject by a single person. However, these are different from a piece of opinion writing. The clear demarking line is that special articles contain the wide and accumulated knowledge of the writer much more than merely his/her opinion. While special write-up are rich in facts, figures and researched data and seek to appeal to the minds of readers, it is the opinion writings which appeal more to the hearts of the readers. The content of such pieces is many times sketchy but appeals to the emotions and sentiments of the readers.

6.3.4 Middles and Opinion Writing

Middles are small pieces meant for light reading containing humor and satire. These pieces are called middles as these are generally placed at the centre of the editorial page. The conventional wisdom tells us that middles are placed to provide comic relief to an otherwise heavy reading of the editorial page containing leaders, special articles by subject specialists and comments by senior writers.

Like opinion pieces middles are also an expression of an individual writer's creativity. However middles do not have the conviction, sharpness and straight and sometimes aggressive approach of an opinion piece.

Barring some honorable exceptions like Busy Bee, middles are often read and forgotten and leave no image of the writer on a reader's mind. As opposed to this an opinion piece defines its writer.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your Answer.

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What is opinion writing?

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2. What is the difference between opinion writing and leader (editorial) writing while both contain the viewpoint of those who write them?

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6.4 UNIVERSE OF OPINION WRITING

An opinion piece can be on any subject or any area in which media readers are interested or can be made to take interest. However, opinion writing is generally done on some subject or topic that is current and in public domain. As you know any writing for media is done while keeping the readers in mind. That is why a journalist or subject expert writes an opinion piece with an eye on the number of readers who will be interested in the opinion piece written and published. Therefore, areas of common interest and general liking are the preferred areas of opinion writing.

It is often said that the present day journalism is focused on four Cs – crime, cinema, celebrities and cricket. A lot of opinion writing is being done in these areas. However, other areas like politics, economic affairs, international affairs and social issues which see a wide divergence of viewpoints, clash of interests and controversy do find a much higher place on the list of preferred areas of interest of opinion writers.

6.4.1 Issues of Politics and Ideology

India is a country which is home to people of different creeds, castes and communities who are represented in our system by different political parties, religions and cultural groups. These groups profess different ideologies and they often come into clash with each other.

The political and ideological differences of these groups influence opinion writing in a big way. The issues of political and differing ideologies offer a big scope for opinion writing.

6.4.2 Social Issues

Our society is, however, passing through a process of rapid social transformation. The social and personal relations are no more being governed by age old traditions. The changing face of society is being viewed from different angles by different people. The clash between tradition and modernization is a fertile area of study and research for our social scientist. This is also an interest area for media which is a mirror to society.

Social issues invoke different reactions from different people, including those who write for media. Issues like caste-based job reservations, woman empowerment, relief and welfare measures for disadvantaged sections of society also provide a big scope for opinion writing.

6.4.3 Issues of Public Policy

Since liberalization of our economy in the last decade of the twentieth century, the debate on public policy has been revolving around the theme of development and

improvement in the living standards of the masses. Since this is a major challenge comprising many aspects of public policy, there is a big debate in the country on what is the right package to reach out economic justice to the people who need it most. The debate is complex as it is multi-dimensional. A lot many aspects of this on-going debate provide good themes and sub-themes for opinion writing.

6.4.4 Issues of Culture and Education

The debate on culture which had been on the back burner because of our preoccupation with economic development in the years since independence in 1947 and it has surfaced in the recent past. The issue of culture invites contradictory and even conflicting viewpoints and there is a marked divergence of opinion on the subject. For opinion writing, culture is a rich and fertile ground. Along with culture education also finds a place in the universe of opinion writing.

6.5 CHARACTERISTICS OF AN OPINION PIECE

Opinion writing in media, both news media as well as non-news media, should have the following characteristics:

6.5.1 Timeliness

The topic chosen and ideas expressed should correspond to the need and requirement of the time. The right time for media writing, as you know will be based on the interest of the audience and their desire to know more on a subject that is currently occupying their interest.

Initiated by the broadcast media and then followed by the social media the need for timeliness of opinion pieces has become even more pronounced. Now audiences want to know about various aspects of a development or happening as quickly as possible. As legendary editor R. Madhvan Nair used to say “anyone writing for media must have the capacity for quick reaction.”

6.5.2 Subject Knowledge, Expertise

The wider your knowledge of men and matters, the more successful you will be as an opinion writer. You can acquire such knowledge mostly by reading and looking out for reading materials on the subject of your interest from all possible sources. Only reading will give you new angles on the issues on which you want to do opinion writing.

In an era of information explosion media audiences are much better informed than the audiences of pre-internet generation. Therefore, present day audiences want to have the content that gives them an insight into the subject of their liking. Therefore, only such opinion pieces find audience approval which have been written by those with deep knowledge of the subject. This is the reason why more and more non-journalists are now writing columns in the journals. Media is also seeking reactions of experts on subjects about which editorial staff cannot speak with authority.

The subject knowledge of an opinion writer has to be based on an understanding of the background and historical interpretation of the topic on which the opinion piece is being written. While one need not give any historical evidence or trace background in an opinion piece, the writer’s knowledge of this must reflect in his piece.

6.5.3 Clarity of Viewpoint

An opinion piece, unlike an editorial or even a feature, has no compulsion to cover all aspects of the subject. The opinion writer should have clarity of mind and a well-defined view on the topic. Media readers appreciate straight and forthright approach of an opinion piece as it helps them in making up their minds.

6.5.4 Unique/ Uncommon Opinion

By instinct, media audiences always look for something new and unique in the content offered to them. Hackneyed style and conventional approach, howsoever well it may be presented, never finds favor with readers, especially among the young and aspiring. Therefore, a good opinion piece must present a unique and uncommon view before the readers.

6.5.5 Keep Audience in Mind

Unlike other formats of writing, opinion writing is a highly personalized and subjective style of writing. While all other writing is done with the view in mind that the reader is the king (on the pattern of the marketing slogan that consumer is the king), an opinion writer does not believe in the dictum that is the reader is the king. The opinion writer rather tries to impose his viewpoint on the audience and expects the audience to follow him. Many a times the audience does follow.

However, a column writer has to keep in mind all the intellectual and emotional dimensions of the audiences. He has to have a very good idea of the audience psyche and should know the limits up to which audience will walk with him. One prerequisite of this is that besides being straight and forthright, the opinion writer should keep his piece simple and sweet. Complex and involved writing will chase away the readers.

6.5.6 Avoid Conflicts

To put across the viewpoint in a straight forward manner is all right for an opinion writer. But he/she should avoid clash with those holding opposing viewpoints. The guiding philosophy of column writing should be rational and logical presentation of a definite viewpoint and not a running down of the opposing viewpoint. A sharp, aggressive and attacking posture does not earn lasting respect for an opinion writer.

6.6 HOW TO PLAN AN OPINION PIECE

While writing an opinion piece may appear simple, but it is not. You have to make good preparations for writing a piece that will sell. Your piece must impress and attract the readers for whom it is written.

6.6.1 Think of a Topic

You have to think of a topic which is a topical and you have the core knowledge to handle it. Your mere interest in a topic should not be the sole reason for writing an opinion piece.

You should not start writing before you know what you are aiming at. Otherwise, you will confuse yourself and your readers who will not know what they are supposed to do with your writing. Think hard before deciding on the topic.

6.6.2 Assess the Eco-system

You have to look to the media environment if you want to successfully market your opinion piece. If you write on the democratic ethos of Holi festival when Diwali is approaching or about the significance of Good Friday when New Year celebrations are about to start nobody will bother to read your piece. Elections in general, IPL or World Cup Cricket or death of a big and popular leader or a major terrorist attack are highly preoccupying events and most of the readers do not want to read anything other than what relates to these events.

In the year 2009, the death of Prime Minister V.P. Singh almost got blacked out from media because of the dastardly terrorist attack in Mumbai which shocked the world and claimed close to 200 lives. V.P. Singh was a highly controversial political leader and but for the terrorist attack his death would have found very good coverage in the media.

While sudden and unexpected developments like terrorist attack or a natural calamity cannot be anticipated, an opinion writer can certainly take care to avoid a clash with something that can be foreseen to time his/her opinion piece.

6.6.3 Collect Material

All good media or non-media writing requires a good study and research by the writer. Opinion writing needs it more as an opinion writer has to take firm and formidable line in support of his/her viewpoint. A good opinion piece, therefore, requires good preparation which can be possible only by reading good literature on the topic. Therefore, collecting good material on the topic is a necessary pre requisite for opinion writing.

6.6.4 Draw an Outline/Define Parameters

To be effective no opinion piece should focus on more than one aspect of a subject. If you are expressing your views on a certain scheme designed for the benefit of small and landless farmers you should not discuss hybrid varieties of seeds and the status of canal irrigation. Before writing you have to set your limits. You must decide what points are to be included in the piece and how it has to move in a direction desired by you.

6.6.5 Think of the Market

Most people will be interested in a piece, even though not very well written, if it is written on what has now come to be known as four “C” – crime, cricket, cinema and celebrity. However, to pick up a topic belonging to this broad area you must look at it well in order to discover a so far untouched area or angle that will impress your readers.

Some newspapers or journals have what is called human angle others have literary angle but all have news angle or the topical touch as we may call it. Keep this in mind while looking to market your product.

6.7 HOW TO WRITE AN OPINION PIECE

Having done proper planning you have to keep the following points in mind while writing in opinion piece.

6.7.1 Importance of intro

Introduction or intro as it is called in newsroom is to a write-up what face is to human body. It is the first introduction of what you are.

You should remember a good opening paragraph wins half the battle. The life of your piece is in the opening paragraph. If it is sharp in focus and opening in nature it makes an instant impact on the mind of the editor. Otherwise, it leaves no impression. Let us also remember most editors do not read a piece beyond the first two paragraphs before deciding to use it in their journal or return it with regards.

6.7.2 Catchy Headlines

Opinion writers are usually not expected to give headlines to the pieces they write as it is the job of the editors who finally clear a piece for publishing. However, headline given by an opinion writer on his/her piece can help editors understand the mind and thrust of the writer. Since a headline is a very brief summary and indicator of what all a writer wants to convey and has tried to convey, it is easy for those whose job it is to assess the news value of the opinion piece and to take a decision.

Writing a headline brings out the best in you as a creative writer. That is why good headlines are often remembered long after the newspaper/journal is forgotten. Headlines are important because a good headline is like a pretty face which instantly attracts you.

6.7.3 The Structure of an Opinion Piece

When we build a house, we first ask an architect to visualize and draw a blueprint and only then allow the mason to touch the building materials. Similarly before taking a pen and paper or opening your laptop, you have to think of all the pieces you have and in what order. It will be better if you write it point-wise.

Intro is of course important but then you have to move quickly to the main body, add descriptive details and then go on to the concluding paragraph. What is important is that you set a word limit and divide it into four basic components of your write-up-intro, body (in which you spell out your main idea in detail), description (where you elaborate on what you have been trying to convey) and finally the conclusion.

Besides this, also please take care of the format. You should have short paragraphs (no paragraph should have more than two or a maximum of three sentences) and the sentences should be short and straight.

6.7.4 Language and Style

The language of a piece should be simple plain and straight. It should not be a burden on the reader's mind. Just compare the two descriptions of a scene first: A tall, narrow-chested, middle-aged man, with graying beard, sat on the green grass trampled down by pedestrians; he sat down quietly, timidly, nervously looking around.

Second: a middle-aged man was sitting on the grass in a public lawn.

The language should be comfortable in tone and non-aggressive in temper. It should never make the reader uneasy or anxious. It is not good if your language has undertones of alarm, irritation and confrontation.

You should write well so that you can connect yourself with the readers, open up their minds and achieve your aim. Language creates a strong impression, good or bad, and exposes the personality of the writer.

Bryon A Garner, author of the best-selling reference work *garner's modern American usage*, says that to express yourself clearly you need to:

- understand that your readers have no time to waste. Therefore, get to the point quickly and clearly.
- use a tone appropriate to your audience (readers).
- emphasize the point most important to your readers. If they feel your message is relevant to them they will read and respond.
- choose an intelligent, non-specialist person among your readers and think that you are writing for that person. Your message will be more appealing and persuasive.

6.7.5 Choice of Words

Words in a sentence or paragraph are like pearls in a necklace. A necklace looks attractive only when all pearls shine. Even one bad pearl compromises the quality of a necklace. Similarly, while writing an opinion piece be careful about every word that you use.

H.W. Flower in his book, "The Kings English", has laid down some rules for the choice of right words while writing. These are:

1. prefer the familiar word to the far-fetched.
2. prefer the concrete word to the abstract.
3. prefer the single word to the circumlocution.
4. prefer the short word to the long.

6.7.6 Editing

Once you have written your piece, you have to do two things – first revise it and then edit it. Revising should be done to ensure that your editorial is giving the message, which you wanted to give to your readers. You can still think of a change in the basic argument put forth by you if you think it is needed.

While revising the draft of your editorial you have to ask yourself the following questions:

- Have I been utterly truthful?
- Have I said all that I needed to say?
- Have I been appropriate, diplomatic and fair?
- Do I have three parts to the piece-an opener, a middle, and a closing?

- In my opener, have I made my points quickly and clearly? And concretely?
- Have I avoided a slow wind-up that unnecessarily postpones the message?
- In the middle, have I proved my points with specifics?
- Is the structure immediately apparent to my readers? Have I used informative headings?
- Is my closing consistent with the rest, yet expressed freshly?
- Have I avoided unnecessary repetition?

Editing is needed to remove any mistakes of spelling or grammar and to time your language. But revision and editing should be done with a cool mind.

Editing is a different art but you need to be careful with your language. You need to check your draft on the following counts.

- Can I save some words here?
- Is there a better way of phrasing this idea?
- Is my meaning unmistakable?
- Is the expression relaxed but refined?
- Does one sentence glide into the next, without discontinuities?

6.7.7 Conclusion

The concluding paragraph of your opinion piece will have to leave your readers happy and satisfied. Therefore, you have to be very careful while writing the last paragraph of your opinion piece to ensure that the last paragraph is good and leaves a lasting impression on the mind of the readers. You have to examine the entire write-up like a judge. Be totally dispassionate while examining all aspects of your piece to ensure its quality. Judge it for language, facts and presentation before you hand it over to the editors for publication.

6.8 SCOPE OF OPINION WRITING

There is hardly a subject nowadays from astrology to nudism that does not have periodical journals devoted to them. A lot of journals, websites and news portals exists on a wide variety of subjects which are always in need of good editorial content. Those who run these smaller news units need content that promotes their chosen area of interest be it political, social or economic. Media organizations seeking to promote the interests of caste and community associations, regional aspirations, furthering interests of professional groups like teachers, lawyers, government servants, small business and NGOs always look for well informed editorial content to promote their case.

Such small news organizations have less resources to be able to employ editorial staff to generate content. They prefer freelancers for the job. And that is your opportunity. However, you will have to work hard to avail yourself of such opportunities. Hard-work involves locating such organizations, understanding their requirements, contacting their editors and then writing to meet their expectations. The challenge is formidable but then scope is also limitless.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your Answer.

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What are the salient points to be kept in mind while writing a piece on opinion writing?

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2. What care should you take while writing a good opinion piece?

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3. What is the scope of marketing opinion writing in the present day world of journalism?

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6.9 LET US SUM UP

In this Unit we have learnt as to what is an opinion piece and how it is different from other forms of media writing such as news stories – straight or interpretative, interviews, features, special articles, middles and editorials.

We have also learnt about the characteristics of a good opinion piece and how it is written. We also learnt as to where it can be marketed and who can be potential buyers.

6.10 FURTHER READING

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6.11 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. In opinion writing, the writer expresses his/ her opinion on a particular current issue or topic. The topic has to be related to some current development that is the theme of public discourse. The subject should be of wide interest and able to arouse curiosity among people who want to know more about it.
2. Editorials, as leaders generally denote broader philosophy of a newspaper or journal and its outlook on various socio-politics and economic issues. Leaders express the consensus of the entire editorial team as well as management of a media organization. As against this, an opinion piece is expression of an individual writer's viewpoint.

Check Your Progress 2

1. Opinion writing in media, both news media as well as non-news media, should have the following characteristics: Timeliness, Subject Knowledge, Expertise, Clarity of Viewpoint, Unique/ Uncommon Opinion, Audience in Mind and Avoid Conflicts
2. While writing a good opinion piece, you should give special importance for the following components besides the subject areas - headline, intro, structure of the opinion piece, clarity of your language and style in which you are presenting your views.
3. Big news organizations can afford to have multiple columnists on diverse subjects, but small news organizations have less resources to be able to employ editorial staff to generate content. They prefer freelancers for the job. And that is your opportunity.

UNIT 7 EDITORIAL WRITING

Structure

- 7.0 Introduction
- 7.1 Learning Outcomes
- 7.2 Newspaper Editorial
 - 7.2.1 Brief History of Editorial Writing
 - 7.2.2 Evolution of Editorial as an Integral Part of Print Media
 - 7.2.3 Editorial and Newspaper Readers
- 7.3 Content of an Editorial
 - 7.3.1 What Do All Editorials Have in Common?
 - 7.3.2 Journals and Editorials
 - 7.3.3 Features of an Editorial
 - 7.3.4 Language of an Editorial
- 7.4 Types of Editorials
- 7.5 Preparing to Write an Editorial
 - 7.5.1 Select a Topic
 - 7.5.2 Firm Up Your Approach
 - 7.5.3 Do Basic Work
 - 7.5.4 Keep Deadline in Mind
 - 7.5.5 Conclusion
- 7.6 How to Write an Editorial
- 7.7 Editorial in the Changing Media Scenario
- 7.8 Let Us Sum Up
- 7.9 Keywords
- 7.10 Further Readings
- 7.11 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

7.0 INTRODUCTION

Editorials or leaders as they are often called are an essential and most important part of a newspaper or journal. These are written by the head of the editorial team or publisher of a newspaper or periodical journal. Editorials are for thinking people and not for a casual or non-serious readers. Leaders of ruling as well as opposition parties, bureaucrats, senior officers and diplomats read the views expressed in the editorials of good newspapers and news magazine with considerable seriousness.

Legendary editors Frank Mores said that in a democracy when the opposition is weak it is the job of the press to act as a strong opposition to the ruling party. While critically examining government policy and performance, editorials act as principal spokesperson of the opposition.

7.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After going through this Unit, you will be able to

- understand the importance of an editorial in a journal;
- appreciate the importance of an editorial in shaping the entire policy thrust of a newspaper's contents be it reporting of small or big events or production of supplements;
- understand the impact an editorial can have on social, political and cultural growth of readers in particular and society general;
- understand the impact of media on policy making by a government and its affiliates;
- appreciate the need for ethical professional standards of objectivity and balance in expression of opinion that is good for serving the larger interests of a society; and
- understand the importance and role of the press as guide and conscience keeper of a society.

7.2 NEWSPAPER EDITORIAL

A journal can be on any theme or a number of themes. There are journals on politics, economy, sports, science, health, environment, law, media, education culture, religious, international relations etc. Then there are national, regional and local newspapers. Every newspapers or journal has its own specific readership. These can have different and even conflicting ideas and ideologies.

Newspapers or journals know what their readers want from them. The editorials are often written keeping the readership in mind.

An editorial is a leading article or leader that presents the opinion of a journal or newspaper on an issue. It reflects the majority view of the editorial board. An editorial is usually unsigned. We can call an editorial an opinion piece on some development that makes news.

You cannot think of any good journal without an editorial. Because of their importance, editorials can be said to be the 'heart and soul' of a journal. In fact, it is the first introduction to a journal. It can also said to be the face of a journal. Newspapers or journals can be inclined towards any socio-economic or cultural group. These can be pro-rich or pro-working class. Editorials reflect their basic character.

7.2.1 Brief History of Editorial Writing

Editorials are the content component of a journal. In fact, the most intimate form of writing for communication is expression of a communicator's personal views or opinion on a subject, the communicator thinks to be of general interest. Viewed in this framework, the editorial writing started when someone thought of conveying the views he/she thought must be shared with everyone who is a member of our information society.

Editorials are basically expression of opinion by an individual or a small group which is viewed as being important for the people by and large. Editorials are not orders, announcements and general instructions or suggestions. The opinions and views contained in an editorial set the tone of public discourse in a democratic set up. Editorials are *vox populi*.

The earliest form of print media, as we call newspapers and periodical journals now, were the newsletters sea-goers used to write from their port- of- call to their parents and families to inform about their welfare. Only after German Goldsmith Johannes Gutenberg developed metallic types fonts in the 15th century, could newspapers come into existence. Therefore, the first editorial of print media history could not have been written before the 16th century. *The Courant*, the first successful newspaper with a fixed periodicity, carrying an editorial appeared only in the year 1702.

7.2.2 Evolution of Editorial as an Integral Part of Print Media

In fact, editorial writing as we understand it today evolved with the onset of professionalism in Indian newspapers. Professionally run newspapers segregated news from views. They earned their place due to the fact that news attracts a reader fast and views or opinions of editors/writers came in next. Newspapers were initially launched to express opinions of the persons who brought them out. All initial newspapers in India, Hickey's Bengal Gazette (1780) to Raja Ram Mohan Roy's *Sambad Kaumudi* (1821) or *Mirat- ul- Akhbar* (1822) were meant to express strongly held beliefs and views of their promoters. This trend continued till the Times of India (1838), The Statesman (1875) and The Pioneer (1864-65), all inspired by the British newspaper industry, appeared in India and gave new professional dimension to print media.

7.2.3 Editorial and Newspaper Readers

Editorials are no doubt the most important component of newspapers. However, their readership is limited. Several studies have revealed that of every hundred persons who read a newspaper or journal hardly 6 to 7 persons care to read the editorials. This is the reason why editorials are placed deep inside of a newspaper and other haughty stuff like crime or accidents finds place on the front page.

The poor readership of editorials of a newspaper can be attributed to several factors. However, the best explanation is that while general news interests each and everyone, editorials attract only serious minded people. Such people form the top layer of society and they often seek the opinions of learned editorial writers and seasoned media professionals for policy making.

Since newspapers are supposed to be vehicles of public opinion, the inputs from a good newspaper's editorials is supposed to represent public opinion.

Any government, especially a democratic government that has to face masses in elections to return to power has to know the public mind well to be able to formulate its policies that appeal to the masses.

Yet another reason for low editorial readership is the fact that most of us seek information but want to keep our beliefs and views secured from the views we do not like. Therefore, while news is received without inhibition we do not want or entertain opinions of others that can influence our thinking or pet beliefs.

However, a lot of newspaper readers repose an unflinching faith in views expressed in editorials and worship editors who write these editorials. Long after their retirement and death. Post-independence readers may remember editors like K. Rama Rao, M. Chelapati Rao, Edalta Narayan, Rusi Karanjia, Shamlal, Frank Moreas, R. Madhvan Nair and Giri Lal Jain.

In the world of Hindi journalism Ajaye, Raghuvir Sahay, Rajendra Mathur, Prabhat Joshi and Manohar Shyam Joshi left a deep impression on the minds of readers of the Hindi belt. As Hindi journalism grew at a fast pace in post-emergency era after 1977, the influence of these editors surpassed even those of big English language dailies like The Hindustan Times and The Times of India.

At regional and local level, many editors of smaller newspapers and magazines leave a deep impact on their readers. And party line news journals like New Age, Saamna, Panchjanya, Samajwadi Bulletin, Mamadhu Amma, Peoples Democracy, Jago Bangla and others almost motivate readers especially those who are party workers, camp followers or admirers of the ideological line of the party they like.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your Answer.
2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What is an editorial?

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2. How old is editorial writing? When were first editorials written.

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7.3 CONTENT OF AN EDITORIAL

Contents of editorials differ from journal to journal. Here we must understand a simple fact i.e. no two journals, be they daily, weekly, fortnightly or monthly are alike. Every journal represents a different thought stream; therefore, contents of all journals are bound to be different from each other. The editorials are written in keeping with the general content of a newspaper or journal.

We now live in a world of what is called *niche* journals. The journals on science, environment and health etc will have contents only of these areas. Naturally editorials will also centre around these subjects.

Whatever the public interest in World Cup Cricket a journal on science will not have an editorial on marks and demerits of the Indian team selected for the World Cup.

7.3.1 What Do All Editorials Have in Common?

However, all editorials have something in common. The common features of all editorials in all newspapers or journals big or small are:

- a journal's policy approach is reflected in views expressed in editorials on certain important developments affecting or attracting people in general. In professional terms this is called the 'editorial line' of a newspaper.
- a persuasive approach to attract and convert the readers to the editorial line taken by the journal towards that development;
- a rational presentation to look reasonable so that it could appeal to the minds of the readers; and
- an inviting and attractive writing style and good language.

All Editorials also have:

- an introduction, body and conclusion like any other media writing.
- a simple explanation of the issue, especially so if the issue is complex and needs elaboration to be understood by lay reader.
- an inviting new angle to attract readers.
- all good editorials talk and discuss issues and not personalities and they also refrain from name-calling.
- a good editorial should take a pro-active approach to be of constructive criticism and contain positive suggestions.
- a good conclusion that satisfies the readers by adding to their knowledge and understanding of the subject.

7.3.2 Journals and Editorials

We can broadly divide all journals on the basis of two categories: *Periodicity* and *Theme*.

Besides daily, weekly, fortnightly and monthly, we have journals on politics and public affairs, economics and financial matters, sports, health, education, home, media, science, agriculture, law, women, children and so on and so forth.

It is only natural that an economic journal will carry an editorial on economic policy and market trends and a sports journal will carry an editorial on an event related to sports.

Different journals carry editorials not only in keeping with the theme of the journal but also in keeping with the taste and requirements (communication needs) of the readers of their journal. As can be easily understood, the taste and character of readership differs from journal to journal and from place to place.

7.3.3 Features of an Editorial

Editor generally look for the following things when writing an editorial:

- that the topic chosen for editorial is *current* and *timely*, and
- it is linked to some recent development of importance; and common interest.

- that the editorial meets the concerns of readers and is relevant to them.
- the topic of the editorial has relevance in catchment area of the publication (where the newspaper or journal is circulated and read).
- that the editorial piece is small and generally not more than 500 words; and
- that it is clearly written and has simple and grammatically correct language.

7.3.4 Language of an Editorial

The language of an editorial has to be simple, straight and sober. It should be such as to go straight to the point and leave no ambiguity in the mind of the reader. It should have force and flow but should be decent and uninvolved. There is no place for slangs and outdated expression in it. It should be impressive without being boisterous.

However, in campaign journalism the norms about language are not observed. Journals brought out by political parties often attack the political opponents of their party in language which is aggressive, indecent and even defamatory. That is the reason you must be wary of words while writing or expressing yourself in media.

Advocacy journalism is also making its appearance felt in Indian media world. While propagating their viewpoint, journalists often use language which is loud and less than decent.

However, use of simple, sober and non-aggressive language is the best as it leaves a lasting impression on the minds of the readers.

7.4. TYPES OF EDITORIALS

Editorials can broadly be categorized into the following:

- 1] **Appreciative:** These editorials admire people and organizations for something done well. They are not common as the traditional role of media in our democratic set-up is critical appraisal of some development and not to give commendation certifications.
- 2] **Critical:** These editorials constructively criticize actions, decisions or situations while providing solutions to the issues under discussion. The Immediate purpose there editorials is to get readers to see and be aware of the problem before country or society.
- 3] **Interpretative:** Editors often use such editorials to explain the way their newspaper thinks about how a sensitive or controversial subject should be handled by the authorities concerned or stake-holders.
- 4] **Persuasive:** Editorials of persuasion aim to give their readers a positive frame of mind so that they are encouraged to take a specific, positive view.
- 5] **Campaign Editorials:** Such editorials are mostly written in journals of political parties, religious organizations or in government publications in support of some programmes of larger social good like pulse polio drive etc.
- 6] **Advocacy Editorials:** Such editorials are often found in the publications of NGOs and other voluntary organizations in subject of the cause they work for. NGOs often work for poor and disadvantaged sections of society like

unorganized labor, poor women and children, and physically challenged people. Editorials in their publications seek support for work for such people.

- 7] **Academic and Philosophic Editorials:** Such editorials are written in academic journals and journals brought out by religious and spiritual organizations.
- 8] **Satirical Editorials:** Often the third editorial in some newspapers especially the Times of India, is a satire. The idea is to give some comic relief to the mind of a reader who is tired of reading heavy stuff on the editorial page. There are some journals based on satire.

However, satire and humor is a dying commodity in today's highly competitive world which is stressed by rat race to perform and surpass others.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your Answer.
2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What are the different types of editorials?

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2. Briefly explain the features of an editorial.

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7.5 PREPARING TO WRITE AN EDITORIAL

For writing an editorial, you need to move in a definite direction and take the following steps:

You should not start writing before you know what you are aiming at otherwise you will confuse your readers who will not know what they are supposed to do with your message. You must make up your mind. This will guide you about what you want to convey and how you say it through your writing.

7.5.1 Select a Topic

The topic you choose is the most important part of writing an editorial for your journal. The best topics are those pertaining to current issues, which are in public domain. Since everyone is interested in such issues, your editorial piece will get instant readership.

7.5.2 Firm up Your Approach

As a media person, you have your own views and opinion on important matters in public discourse. Besides your opinion on the policy of your organization on a topic of current interest also matters. Therefore, have a definite policy line on the issue.

For instance, one political party wants article 370 of the constitution granting special status to the state of Jammu and Kashmir to be abrogated. The other party wants it to be retained.

You need to ask yourself, are you for it or against. You have to choose before you write your editorial on this subject. You cannot be on both sides of issue. An editorial must express an opinion clearly.

7.5.3 Do Basic Work

First of all think of a good but small two-three word headline that will attract a reader's attention and motivate him/her to read your editorial.

While writing a good editorial you must have necessary facts, figures and even quotes of knowledgeable people in support of your line of argument. Moreover, you should use data to prove your line of argument. Steadily develop your case in support of your editorial line so that the strongest argument comes in the end and convinces the reader.

7.5.4 Keep Deadline in Mind

In media, you are always racing against time. Deadlines are important. While writing editorial that you should always keep deadline in mind. Since we are not supposed to leave any mistake in an editorial, it is revised again and again and this takes time.

7.6 HOW TO WRITE AN EDITORIAL

The following is a 10-point recipe for you to write an editorial:

- 1) **The Theme / Subject:** Present your views briefly but unequivocally using fact and figures where necessary.
- 2) **The Presentation:** Talk about the issue clearly and say why it is important.
- 3) **The Approach:** Look rational. Discuss the opposite viewpoint as well.
- 4) **The Language:** Use key words again and again for the readers to understand it well.
- 5) **The Thrust:** Encourage critical thinking and pro-active reaction.
- 6) **The Wordage:** Restrict it to 500 words.
- 7) **The Style:** Never use "I" in an editorial even if you are the boss of newspaper or periodical.
- 8) **Revision:** Once done you have to do two things – first revise it and then edit it. Revising should be done to ensure that your editorial is giving the message which you wanted to give to your readers. You can still think of a change in the basic argument put forth by you. Think if it is needed.

While revising the draft of your editorial you have to ask yourself the following questions:

- Have I been utterly truthful?

- Have I said all that I needed to say?
 - Have I been appropriately diplomatic and fair?
 - Do I have three parts to the piece-an opener, a middle, and a closer?
 - In my opener, have I made my points quickly and clearly? And concretely?
 - Have I avoided a slow wind-up that unnecessarily postpones the message?
 - In the middle, have I proved my points with specifics?
 - Is the structure immediately apparent to my readers? Have I used informative headings?
 - Is my closer consistent with the rest-yet expressed freshly? Have I avoided lame repetition?
- 9) **Editing:** Editing is needed to remove any mistakes of spelling or grammar and to time your language. But revision and editing should be done with a cool mind.

Editing is a different art but you need to be careful with your language. You need to check your draft on the following counts.

- can I save some words here?
 - Is there a better way of phrasing this idea?
 - Is my meaning unmistakable?
 - Is the expression relaxed but refined?
 - Does one sentence glide into the next, without discontinuities?
- 10) **Conclusion:** In an editorial, your conclusion should sum up all that you have written about. The conclusion should create an impact on the minds of readers and they should feel satisfied even if not convinced.

7.7 EDITORIALS IN THE CHANGING MEDIA SCENARIO

Change is the law of nature. As a society changes with time media too has to change and reinvent itself. The pace of change can be slow or fast depending on several factors. The massive changes in information and communication technology (ICT) in the past few decades or the computer/internet revolution as we call it also has had a deep impact on media world. The journals and their editorials have also changed with the change in technology.

New Information technology has converted our world into a global village. There is deluge of information. Therefore, there is no need for editorial writers now to draw attention of audience to those information inputs that used to be privilege of the elite and were not in public domain. Readers now a days know facts and are aware of many things but they are often not able to comprehend and analyse what they know.

With so much of information, all around the audience also makes up its minds on various public policy issues of economy and polity. This has limited the role of editorial writer as an opinion maker and perspective giver.

In the past decades, we have also witnessed death of ideology. Debates are, no more done on communism or capitalism. Political parties do raise slogans but without ideological moorings. Literature and other areas of creative expressions are also losing ideological undertones. This is also impacting media and editorial writers. The emerging scenario is witnessing editorial writing without any ideological basis. In the 20th century, journalism ideology was a guiding light for most of the editorial writers.

Moreover, due to impact of modernization, ethical standards have also undergone a change, social norms are changing and traditions are fast disappearing giving way to new behavioral patterns. We now live in an open society. The media has to cater to a new generation of readers who are different from their parents generation.

Now the editorials are no more heavy on thought and lack theoretical background. The reason is easy to understand. Often editorials, even in well-reputed journals betray absence of any sense of history. Editorials or historicals are now being addressed to mass audiences instead of a sober and thinking class as before and this has changed both their language and content.

Other things being equal, it is obvious that the wider your knowledge of men and affairs the more successful you are likely to be. Such knowledge must come chiefly through reading, and the habit of reading is one you would do well to acquire.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your Answer.
2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. How do you plan to write an editorial?

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2. How is the content and character of editorials changing?

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7.8 LET US SUM UP

In this Unit, we have told you about the importance of an editorial in a newspaper or periodical journal. Our effort has been to familiarize you with all aspects of editorial writing. To do so, we gave you the definition of the editorial, listed its basic character, its evolution and historical background and the art of editorial writing.

We have also tried to familiarize you with various types of editorials and the changing scenario of the world of editorials. We have also told you about the language, size and placement of the editorial and the need for balance and accuracy so that the editorials written by you have credibility and are read with respect.

7.9 KEYWORDS

- Campaign Editorials** : Such editorials are mostly written in journals of political parties, religious organizations or in government publications in support of some programmes of larger social good like pulse polio drive.
- vox populi** : It is a Latin words. Its direct meaning is ‘Voice of People’.
- Editorial** : It presents the opinion of a newspaper on an issue. It reflects the majority view of the editorial board.

7.10 FURTHER READINGS

1. Knight, R. M. (2010). Journalistic writing: Building the skills, honing the craft. Marion Street Press.
2. Sullivan, K. D., & Eggleston, M. (2006). The McGraw-Hill desk reference for editors, writers, and proof readers. McGraw-Hill Companies.
3. Saxena, S. (2006). Headline writing. Sage.
4. Mencher, M., & Shilton, W. P. (1997). News reporting and writing. Brown & Bench mark Publishers.
5. Fink, C. C. (1999). Writing opinion for impact. Iowa State University Press.
6. Gillan, C., & Evans, H. (2010). Essential English for journalists, editors and writers. Random House.
7. Parhi, A. R. (2008). Indian English through newspapers. Concept Publishing Company.

7.11 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. An editorial is a leading article or leader that presents the opinion of a journal or newspaper on an issue. It reflects the majority view of the editorial board.
2. Only after German goldsmith Johannes Gutenberg developed metallic types fonts in the 15th century, could newspapers come into existence. Therefore, the first editorial of print media history could not have been written before the 16th century. *TheCourant* , the first successful newspaper with a fixed periodicity, carrying an editorial appeared only in the year 1702.

Check Your Progress 2

1. There are eight broad types of editorials, namely Appreciative, Critical, Interpretative, Persuasive, Campaign Editorials, Advocacy Editorials, Academic and Philosophic Editorials and Satirical Editorials.

2. Generally, an editorial contains the topic which is *current* and *timely*, and it is linked to common interest, relevant to readers, generally not more than 500 words. And that it is clearly written and has simple and grammatically correct language.

Check Your Progress 3

1. For writing an editorial, you need to move in a definite direction and take the following steps: Select a Topic, Firm up Your Approach, Do Basic Work, and Keep Deadline in Mind.
2. There is no need for editorial writers now to draw attention of audience to those information inputs that used to be privilege of the elite and were not in public domain. Readers nowadays know facts and are aware of many things but they are often not able to comprehend and analyze what they know. Now the editorials are no more heavy on thought and lack theoretical background. The reason is easy to understand. Often editorials, even in well-reputed journals betray absence of any sense of history.



UNIT 8 WRITING FOR MAGAZINES

Structure

- 8.0 Introduction
- 8.1 Learning Outcomes
- 8.2 Historical Background of the 'Magazine'
- 8.3 Definition: What is a Magazine?
- 8.4 What Does Magazine Writing Constitute?
- 8.5 Characteristics of Magazine Writing
- 8.6 Functions of Magazines
- 8.7 How to Write for Magazines?
 - 8.7.1 Magazine Writing Styles
 - 8.7.2 Difference between Writing for Magazines and Other Journalistic Writings
- 8.8 Categories of Magazine Writing
 - 8.8.1 Various Genres of Magazine Writing
 - 8.8.2 Sharp Decline in Magazine Journalism-Setback to Magazine Writing
- 8.9 How to Choose Topics for Magazine Writing
 - 8.9.1 Sources for Material and Research for Magazine Writing
- 8.10 Which Magazine Will Publish My Writings?
- 8.11 Let Us Sum Up
- 8.12 Further Readings
- 8.13 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

8.0 INTRODUCTION

As you would perhaps know that though the daily newspaper dominates the print medium in every country all over the world, magazines, periodicals, and journals also command a very large following among mass media audience. For example, in India alone, there are over 90,000 newspapers, including magazines and periodicals as per the latest (May 2012) figures released by the Information and Broadcasting Ministry-affiliated office of the Registrar of Newspapers of India (RNI), that keeps a complete records of all newspapers, periodicals, magazines and journals in all languages and of all periodicities published anywhere in the whole country. Hence, periodicals, journals and magazines in English, local Indian and foreign languages, being published in India are a crucial and significant part of the nation's print media industry today.

You may also be aware of the fact that print journalism in India made its debut in January 1780 in the shape of a weekly news magazine. India's first newspaper was started by an Englishman, James Augustus Hickey, 'The Calcutta Gazette', also known by the title of 'The Calcutta General Advertiser', was a news weekly

publication to begin with. There were, of course, no daily newspapers published during those days. But, soon after that, many other similar periodicals and journals were brought out in many local Indian languages as weekly or monthly magazines.

Thereafter, it took several years for magazine journalism in India to flourish and expand. However, since the dawn of independence in 1947, magazine publishing in every language has profusely prospered and expanded. Greater spurt in the magazine publishing in India came in the aftermath of the 1975 National Emergency. Right now, magazines are being brought out in more than 120 languages and dialects (RNI's figures) of India and read by millions of people across the country. Therefore, you will notice that magazine journalism indeed has a bright future in India's mass media scenario. Obviously, writing for magazines will offer umpteen lucrative opportunities.

8.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

In this Unit, we will endeavour to introduce you to:

- the world of magazine writing;
- define what is a magazine;
- various characteristics of magazine writing;
- what constitutes writing for magazines;
- how magazine writing is done;
- magazine writing styles;
- difference between magazine writing & other journalistic writing;
- categories of magazines;
- various genres of magazine writing;
- how to choose topics for magazine writing;
- sources for material and research for magazine writing;
- which magazine will publish my article;
- let us sum up;
- revision questions;
- further readings.

8.2 HISTORICAL BACKGROUND OF THE 'MAGAZINE'

The 'Magazine' is said to have originated in England in the second half of the 18th century, when noted writers in English, such as Daniel Defoe, Richard Steele and others, started doing critiques of literary works of the upcoming young authors-poets, novelists and essayists. Remember poets John Keats and P.B. Shelley who became victims of trenchant criticism that killed them. Such literary criticism was published in occasional, informal sheets and bulletins. 'Review' was the first such a magazine.

These magazines in those days' England generally dealt with diverse subjects, such as local politics, public tastes and morals, social traditions and customs, elite opinion and enlightened commentaries in cynical, critically destructive styles.

The 'magazine' idea caught up, and two other literary magazines, such as 'Tatler' and 'Spectator', in identical style, strain and tone followed. These magazines soon became popular among the rich and high society middle class elite. It is believed the title 'magazine' as applied to a periodical collection was first used in 1731 by 'Gentlemen's Magazine'.

8.3 DEFINITION: WHAT IS A 'MAGAZINE?'

Though it is hard to define 'magazine', according to the website, dictionary.com, the meaning of the word 'magazine' is a periodical containing a collection of articles, short stories, features and other such writings. A magazine is a publication that has articles and photographs, A magazine is a regularly published journal or periodical containing written or published articles that people find entertaining, informative, interesting, and is useful. Essentially, it must have more than one contribution / write-up.

The expression 'magazine' is also used to describe 'a container that carries a number of similar-shaped articles, such as rifle bullets.' Yet another definition states that a magazine is a small publication that 'informs, inspires, enriches your personality, and gives you entertainment at regular intervals.' Magazines are mostly published weekly, bi-weekly, fortnightly, monthly quarterly, six-monthly and annually. A terse definition describes a magazine as a 'bound stack of pages, one can scribble on and –pass on.'

Thus, today we have various kinds of magazines for all kinds of people pursuing divergent interests, occupations, hobbies, and ventures equipped with special, specific and unique intellectual and educational levels. Though of late, due to inflation, the ubiquitous electronic media, and 24x7 internet, these magazines are being priced very high and are becoming out of reach for common readers. However, a fairly large number of readers are still able to afford to buy some magazine or the other.

Meanwhile, by the end of 19th century, magazines did come to strategize, and become a valuable source of information and education, and have since occupied a strong and permanent pedestal in mass media scenario all over the world. Besides, the print medium, the 'magazine' has etched an important *niche* in internet, radio and television media platforms. Such magazines are being termed as 'e-zines' Obviously, hurt by inflation, magazine journalism has broadened its spectrum as readers' interests have also varied and multiplied.

8.4 WHAT DOES MAGAZINE WRITING CONSTITUTE?

Writing for magazines needs numerous unique qualities and skills. Do not forget that any magazine writing should concern more with issues and trends that directly impact hundreds of people. But the fact is that each and every magazine can not target all audiences at the same time. Therefore, magazines have necessarily to narrow down their scope to serve '*niche*' audiences.

Thus, one has to work hard to expand one's own horizon by reading other people's writings in the magazine(s) that one envisages to contribute one's writings to. So, to begin with, one needs to assess, and evaluate one's own interests and limitations, then proceed preparing for the task. Specifically speaking, these days magazine writing constitutes: first and foremost, excellent command on the language one wishes to write in, i.e., adequate knowledge and nuances of grammar, syntax, synonyms, latest vocabulary, even slangs and clichés.

One must keep a regular tab on new developments, recent thinking, facts and figures, newest innovations, references and contexts of others' contributions in the chosen field. Remember, no one likes to be caught on the wrong foot and if one is caught one may have to pay a heavy price of being blacklisted.

In order to have one's writing accepted in famous magazines, one has to expand and include recent most writings of others on the area(s) one intends to do writing on. And in any case, it is always prudent to specialize in one or some selected area (s), or a branch of an area for being considered and known as a 'specialist'.

Usually, most magazines deal with topics of general, common / everyday interests that concern the man on the street, such as politics, economics, current affairs, international events and human interest events of recent occurrence. While writing these articles, you have to be totally in tune with the general policy contours, angles, likes and dislikes of the editor and the owners of the magazines one opts to write for. Though some magazines do entertain and accept opposing viewpoints, but then there are 'policy' riders.

However, there are numerous magazines that concentrate on select subjects: for example, defence and national security, economics and finance, sports and games, women and gender concerns, societal issues and communities, movies, films, cinema, radio, television and entertainment, fashion and life styles, so on.

Therefore, the field is wide open; if one makes early choice; and if the interests and choices are intensely and extensively pursued, it is easier and quicker to create one's place in the field.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your Answer.

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. Trace the origins of 'magazines'.

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2. What are the essential ingredients of magazine writing?

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8.5 CHARACTERISTICS OF MAGAZINE WRITING

As you would have noticed, every magazine's shape, structure and setup are completely different from a daily broadsheet or even a tabloid newspaper. Similarly, number of pages and contents, also often vary widely. Some of the well known and focused, special characteristics of magazine writing include: straight, simple, precise, to the point sentences; direct, but full of meaning, pregnant language; intimate details, requisite facts and figures, deeply dug, intensely researched statistics, objectively analyzed. Strong creative ideas lead to action. Be the creator of such ideas.

Magazine readership being large, specialized, concerned and much more enlightened expects a sound, academically truthful, verified and verifiable, authoritative statements adequately supported by learned text. This marks the general characteristics of magazine writing.

8.6 FUNCTIONS OF MAGAZINES

Since magazines are often patronized by intelligent, enlightened and highly intellectual readership, magazine editors are always on the look out for writings that help meet such readers' expected needs and aspirations and support their research pursuits, inculcate new and fresh research ideas in new, unexplored directions.

Therefore, the most cherished objectives and functions of magazine writing is to etch new paths in grappling with complex issues, resolving intricate propositions, handling arduous and demanding situations,

Subjects for magazine writing include: novel, rare, impact-related, conflict/tension solving ideas; thoughtful engines or creating new and healthy controversy; reformist, well meaning, polished, urbane, top quality, illustrious, refined intricately detailed plans, strategies, genuinely well-intentioned suggestions and more... Such contributions are eagerly sought for, anxiously awaited and eagerly welcomed by all standard magazines worthy of their titles.

8.7 HOW TO WRITE FOR MAGAZINES?

Writing for magazines requires extraordinarily depth of knowledge about all that is happening around us in this world, particularly in the areas of greatest common concern. If one is set for a chosen area or specialization for magazine writing, it becomes easy to go ahead and start sharpening one's faculties for accomplishing the task of writing for the magazine. The following tips would further help in writing for magazines: actually, there are two ways of accomplishing your goal-read a lot; identify good writings and try to pattern your writing similarly. But do not copy; plagiarizing is illegal and unprofessional.

Next, scan the market, pick up the magazine (s) you will wish to work for; accept any job offer there. Work hard prove to your mite; have persistence; make every effort to do the given job well; show your seniors you know the magazine; and you are absolutely equipped to meet its grinding requirements. Determination, grit, guts pay.

It is but sure that if you are good and know your job well and can perform you will get noticed and get prized magazine writing assignments you have been

hankering for. But, be prepared to accept low emoluments for the time being. Also, may be no rewards at all.

Strive to be original, invent new ideas, brood over and discover new horizons for your writings; carve out new avenues. It is really not difficult at all. Once it is done and succeeds, the path is open.

Meanwhile, keep refurbishing your own personal sources for fresh ideas with rare newspaper clippings, new magazines, new books, new contacts, references. Your own library can be an excellent source for your new assignments. Keep looking around for doing this.

8.7.1 Magazine Writing Styles

In one word, magazine writing style is much different from news writing, and in fact all other types of writing. Traditional news writing follows the ‘pyramid’ technique, i.e., begin with the most important segment of the news, and then in descending order, the story is written. Editorial writing and interviewing are just another cup of tea.

But writing for magazine pursues just the opposite path. One can begin even without giving a tiny clue. And magazine writing need not be in 5W, 1H style of news writing.

Magazine writing style has to be softly literary with greater wordplay, refined prose, well-wrought sentences and greater high level imagination. Magazing writers enjoy word manipulation. Remember, Bacon who said: ‘Style is the man’ (now, also woman). Try to craft your own individual style. Magazine editors will love you once your style appeals to the reader.

Generally speaking, the following are the essential elements of the style: simple, but imaginative introduction; plain, smooth, racy, smooth flowing language; precision, orderliness and chronological organization and sincerity, transparency and simplicity in presentation of the researched material on the topic under treatment.

The technique involves imagery, choice and placement of words, suitably fitting quotations in support of the topic, strengthening and tightening the overall write-up.

The magazine article generally begins with off-the-cuff ideas. Because if a particular piece of writing has to click; it should begin with an element that should shock, surprise, please, strike, sadden, hurt, provoke, answer prevailing puzzlements of the reader. In fact, the styles are limitless. It isn’t really hard to hit the nail on the head, and shell out a piece that clicks with the editor, and then with the readers that will make you the darling of everybody.

Generally accepted style for magazine writings is tight design; an arresting intro, a cogent theme— doled out point by point and adequately explained without wasting words, presented slickly, precisely, strikingly, one-by-one, paragraph after paragraph with not more than two or three sentences in each paragraph.

One can sporadically throw in anecdotes, sayings, illustrations, quotations, adages, tit bits, and even jokes. Such writings often make magazines sell and endear with writers.

Finally, it is believed that every style should have three essential characteristics: clarity, force and flavour. Which means the ideas should be clear to the reader;

these should be presented with full force. And after reading the piece, essentially, the reader should get the flavor and should feel that it was not a waste of time to read the piece.

What is crucial to the style is that there should be logical, sequence connection between words, phrases, sentences and paragraphs-focus, flow, pace, rhythm and emphasis. The reader should be satisfied, happy, smiling that he gained something from this piece and he will read your piece again.

2. Difference Between Writing for Magazines and Other Journalistic Writings

As explained earlier, writing for magazines is quite different from all other journalistic writings. Hard news writing and magazine writing are different right from first sentence that contain answers to 5W's and 1H, due to the pyramid structure and steps that follow. Also, due to the urgency, the time factor in their publication and finally, reader's access.

Editorial writing is different from writing for the magazines as essentially it is an opinion piece-taking clearly sides. It is even a biased, prejudiced piece, as the opinion is that of the Editor, views of the Editorial Board, or the owner of the publication. An editorial is short; crisp, between 500 and 1,000 words. Editorials are written day after day, on a controversial, current, topical subject-political, economic, defence, security, national, international, social or any other issue of wide interest to the readers.

An interview piece is different from a magazine piece since it generally deals with views of one person who is in the news, or has achieved some unique laurel-awarded Nobel Prize, Bharat Ratna, scaled Mount Everest, only survivor of air crash, rail accident, etc.

Writing reviews of films, theatrical, and dramatic, performances, music recitals, art and fashion shows are also different from magazine writings in technique, content and style. While many magazines do publish special articles on all or any of these areas, but, again these writings are timely, of current importance and published soon after these events take place, whereas magazine writings have longer shelf life of months, even years.

Magazine writings are also quite different from newspaper articles and interviews stories. Newspaper articles and interview stories are traditionally printed in narrow columns; while magazine pieces are generally displayed with photographs, caricatures, free hand cartoons and drawings, decorative and floral rules and margins, bold-lettered boxes separated by thick rules, etc.

Technically staff-wise, magazine writers are more focused on their individual specializations while newspaper journalists are heavily oriented towards covering routine pieces on current, topical issues. Besides, characteristically magazine journalists are academically well qualified, experienced and also enjoy fat pay packets. While magazines are read to fulfill specific aims, newspapers most often only provide daily news packages.

Also, readership levels, sections and categories in both the cases, vary widely in journalism. Magazines often have a sort of flexible deadlines, whereas daily newspapers' and even weekly magazines' deadlines are strict and time-bound, often inflexible.

8.8 CATEGORIES OF MAGAZINE WRITING

Actually, it is not possible to strictly pin down, and rigidly categorise magazine writings as most magazines have their own mandate, their individual objects and exclusive themes. And they have to stick to the prescribed and chosen areas of their specialization. Those who wish to write for those magazines, too have to meet their requisite demands and needs. There could be two or more magazines devoted to one theme.

However, as magazines can roughly be divided into three or four broad categories, the categories of magazine writing has obviously to conform to these magazines' mandates and pre-determined aims and objects. According to one view, while specialized magazines abound, general magazines dominate. Thus, those looking for opportunities for writing assignments for these magazines will be expected to meet their general and specific subject matter needs.

Here is a generally classified list of some theme categories of magazines and journals that accept writings in furtherance of their individual, avowed and committed focus:

1. Consumer, general interest magazines, e.g., Outlook, India Today, The Week, Frontline, Reader's Digest, etc.
2. Trade or business magazines, e.g., Economic & Political Weekly, Business Today, Business India, Businessworld, Travel Outlook, University News, etc.
3. Specialized magazines, e.g., Sportsworld, Sportstar, Femina, Filmfare, Savvy, Celebrity, etc.

There is yet another classification of magazine categories: travel, Science & Technology, lifestyles, literary, higher education, and general education, trade and industry, autos and motoring, health and well being, mass media-advertising and public relations, television, movies, theatre, music, airlines and aviation,... the list is extending as people's needs and aspirations multiply.

8.8.1 Diverse Genres of Magazine Writing

Due to rapid material and economic developments, rise in literacy rates, besides hunger for information and multiplying political awareness, newspapers, particularly the language press industry in India has been booming during the last decade or so. But, as mentioned earlier, the magazine industry in India has suffered a great deal. With the result, writing for magazines has also lost a lot of its shine of yesteryears. Also most Sunday supplements of daily newspapers do not entertain freelance contributions for magazine as they have dedicated staff writers for Sunday and weekday supplements.

However, scope still exists for avid, competent and enterprising magazine writers. Therefore, genres of writing for magazine have also become immensely specialized and highly rare. Some of the following areas are currently popular for magazine writing: computer, science and technology (S&T) global political and economic trends, mass media and entertainment, higher education and social research, travel and adventure, defence and security, poverty and deprivation alleviation, international economic upheaval, recession, commerce and world trade.

8.8.2 Sharp Decline in Magazine Journalism – Setback to Magazine Writing

It needs to be pointed out here that during the past two decades, the magazine industry in India has suffered enormously. Hundreds of excellent magazines have shut down due to heavy and prohibitive production costs-expensive printing equipment, heavy rise in newsprint prices, big increase in labour wages and other allied jobs. Journalistically speaking, in India the place of magazines has been grabbed by the weekday and Sunday multi-colour supplements of almost all daily newspapers. Weekday supplements also carry rich and absorbing reading materials. Therefore, the disappearance of magazines from the periodical scene in India is now sorely felt, but apparently it seems to have been accepted by editors and publishing managements. Moreover, the reading habit of people has also radically declined due to the immensely rich fare offered by the 24x7 programming of cable and pay television in every national language and dialect all over the country.

8.9 HOW TO CHOOSE TOPICS FOR MAGAZINE WRITING

As pointed out earlier, while the scope for magazine writing is not really restricted, contributions on some of the topics listed above can and do find acceptance in some prestigious and elite magazines that are still being published. Though lavishly produced and highly priced, these magazines are avidly patronized by top management executives, civil servants, senior defence and security personnel, university teachers, educators, former and working media persons, working journalists; many of them also being regular contributors. They often write on current professional issues counting on their rich experiences of working at national and international levels.

Though the scope for magazine writing is increasingly getting restricted, there are numerous avenues where pieces suiting general focus of the magazines enumerated above do find outlets. Travel, for example, is a popular area these days as world watching has been catching up everywhere. Another area is lifestyles and fashion. Men and women with refined tastes and sensibilities can find ready possibilities for writing on changing trends of daily wear, festive wear, and special occasion wears. Besides, depending on climate, weather conditions and other factors apparel designs are making global news and creating demands.

Similarly, real estate and furniture industries are making waves all over the world, including India. A Danish furniture multinational giant, Ikea, recently announced its intentions to set up shop in India. Real estate industry suddenly made news when American economist Robert Shiller with another researcher won the 2013 Economics Nobel prize for presenting their research findings on the international fiscal trends in real estate industry.

Therefore, as you access new and foreign journals on the latest and emerging topics, you will discover magazines devoted to these new areas which are looking for country-specific contributions. With overall advancement and urge for new trends and exquisite styles in every field, innovative ideas are taking over. As the world is uniting fast in needs, yearnings, applications, and uses, lifestyle magazine writings also will have to reflect these trends and styles.

8.9.1 Sources for Material & Research for Magazine Writing

As you proceed to write on new and emerging topics, you will discover that it is really not so easy and smooth to accomplish many of the innovative assignments. Therefore, you will have to do a lot of fresh thinking, intense study, exhaustive research, tap new sources and contact experts. Besides, you will also need to refer to standard and latest publications and researches on the areas you are working. While the libraries are repositories of knowledge and information, but you will need to tap the right sources.

Hence, it will be prudent to start with electronic search with electronic database: google will be the obvious choice. Wikipedia.com, the 'Fact on File' website could be another source, and followed by already printed materials on the topic you are working on, and /or similar allied areas of the topic. Look for old newspapers from archives-mostly available on internet, or well known libraries, clippings and files. Annual Year Books, Statistical Directories, Guidebooks, seeking special inputs through right to information (RTI) process, Who's Who, World Almanac also contain useful input and information from specialized collections. While these are only some of the clues to gather material for your topic, the fact of the matter is that one has to find one's own way to find what one is looking for. And, one should know what one is looking for.

8.10 WHICH MAGAZINE WILL PUBLISH MY ARTICLE?

After going through this Unit, you will hopefully be inspired, provoked, prompted and eager to write for some magazines. You will perhaps ask: Where can I find ideas to write for magazines? And which magazine should I approach for writing? Who should I ask this? Who can introduce me to such magazines? Well, our suggestion is: Read this Unit again, and yet again. It is for sure that many of your questions and anxieties will be answered.

But if not, here is what you should do immediately: read at least two or three daily newspapers. You will surely come across some ideas for writing articles that will suit magazines. Ask yourself: critically, frankly, honestly: can you write on any of the subjects that occurs to you. And then comprehensively assess and evaluate your own weaknesses and strengths: can you write on the subject that strikes you. And, then again, ask yourself what is it you think you love to read most on that topic. Again and again, brood.

In addition, look for the magazine that interests you utmost. Locate its old issues and read as many of these as you can get; access all its issues of the current month, or year. Identify which of the topics in this magazine that appeals to you most. Think of allied areas of these and other identical topics. List a few of these; consult your friends, teachers or some media persons for advice. You should be able to find some solid answer to your yearning. Pursue it sincerely; go out and tap some of the sources suggested in this Unit, and with all your yearnings. Sit down in a room and write in any way you can.

Meanwhile, do some more reading on this very subject. Once again go through your first draft. See how it reads. Revise it and continue the process till you are satisfied. The process goes on. And, surely one day you will make it.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space given below for your Answer.

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. Identify some of the well-known sources of researching material for writing for magazines.

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2. What do you think is scope and future of independent magazine writing in India? Illustrate your answer.

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8.11 LET US SUM UP

In this Unit, we introduced you to the world of magazines; defined what a magazine is; what are the characteristics, and ingredients of magazine writing; various *genres* of magazine writing; how to choose a topic for magazine writing, and how and where to do research to find material for writing for magazines. Finally, we suggested as to how you can start writing.

8.12 FURTHER READINGS**LIST OF BOOKS ON MAGAZINE JOURNALISM**

1. Holmes, Tim&Nice, Liz. (2012). MAGAZINE JOURNALISM. SAGE, New Delhi.
2. Tebbel, John. (1969). AMERICAN MAGAZINE. Hawthorne Books, New York.
3. Hermes, Joke. (1995). READING WOMEN'S MAGAZINES. Polity Press, Cambridge
4. Norberto& Oliva, Alberto. (2004). MAGAZINES—that make history, their origin, development and influence. University Press of Florida, Gainesville, Florida, USA

8.13 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS**Check Your Progress 1**

1. The 'Magazine' is said to have originated in England in the second half of the eighteenth century.

These magazines in those days' England generally dealt with diverse subjects, such as local politics, public tastes and morals, social traditions and customs,

elite opinion and enlightened commentaries in cynical, critically destructive styles. It is believed the title ‘magazine’ as applied to a periodical collection was first used in 1731 by ‘Gentlemen’s Magazine’.

2. Magazine writing constitutes: first and foremost, excellent command on the language one wishes to write in, i.e., adequate knowledge and nuances of grammar, syntax, synonyms, latest vocabulary-even slangs and clichés.

Check Your Progress 2

1. It will be prudent to start with electronic search with electronic database: google will be the obvious choice. Wikipedia.com, the ‘Fact on File’ website could be another source, and followed by already printed materials on the topic you are working on, and /or similar allied areas of the topic. Look for old newspapers from archives-mostly available on internet, or well known libraries, clippings and files. Annual Year Books, Statistical Directories, Guidebooks, seeking special inputs through right to information (RTI) process, Who’s Who, World Almanac also contain useful input and information from specialized collections.
2. Due to rapid material and economic developments, rise in literacy rates, besides hunger for information and multiplying political awareness, newspapers, particularly the language press industry in India has been booming during the last decade or so. But, as mentioned earlier, the Magazine industry in India has suffered a great deal. With the result, writing for magazines has also lost a lot of its shine of yesteryears. Also most Sunday supplements of daily newspapers do not entertain freelance contributions for magazine as they have dedicated staff writers for Sunday and weekday supplements.



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